Part A

From a utilitarian standpoint, an ethical search engine should make choices that benefit the greatest number of people. Google ranks pages using factors such as relevance, content quality, expertise, and location (Google, n.d.). As a result, it does not deliberately exclude views just because only a small group holds them. Still, minority opinions may appear lower in results when their sites have fewer links or attract less attention.

Kulshrestha et al. (2019) examined bias in web search and showed how both available information and ranking systems shape what users see. This raises an ethical issue, since minority groups may hold important information that is hard to find. For example, a small community might notice a social problem before it gains wider attention.

From a utilitarian view, the consequences of these decisions matter. If Google's algorithm makes valuable minority views hard to find, society may lose useful information and different perspectives. At the same time, unpopular opinions should not rank higher merely because they are unpopular.

Overall, Google's algorithm does not intentionally exclude minority opinions, but its ranking system can reduce their visibility. Google should seek to offer relevant and reliable information while also making sure useful minority viewpoints can be found.

Part B

From a Kantian ethical perspective, every person deserves respect and should have the chance to express their views. However, respecting people does not mean every opinion must receive the same ranking or be treated as equally reliable.

People should have a fair opportunity to share their views online. At the same time, search engines have a duty to help users find accurate and useful information. For example, giving a well-supported scientific finding the same credibility as a false proven claim could mislead people.

Draws et al. (2021) studied how biased search rankings can shape users' attitudes toward debated topics. This shows why search engines must consider how the order of results may affect what people believe. Similarly, Olsson et al. (2025) examined Google search results about immigration and found differences in the viewpoints presented and where they appeared in the results.

In my view, every opinion deserves fair consideration, but not every opinion deserves equal credibility. Search engines should not suppress a viewpoint simply because it is unpopular. However, relevance, evidence, and reliability should influence which results appear first.

In conclusion, ethical search engines should respect people's right to express their views while helping users tell reliable information apart from misinformation. Fair treatment does not require treating every claim as equally true.

References

Google. (n.d.). A guide to Google Search ranking systems. Google Search Central. https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/ranking-systems-guide

Kulshrestha, J., Eslami, M., Messias, J., Zafar, M. B., Ghosh, S., Gummadi, K. P., & Karahalios, K. (2019). Search bias quantification: Investigating political bias in social media and web search. Information Retrieval Journal, 22(1–2), 188–227. https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10791-018-9341-2

Draws, T. A., Tintarev, N., Gadiraju, U., Bozzon, A., & Timmermans, B. (2021). This is not what we ordered: Exploring why biased search result rankings affect user attitudes on debated topics. In Proceedings of the 44th International ACM SIGIR Conference on Research and Development in Information Retrieval (pp. 295–305). Association for Computing Machinery. https://dl.acm.org/doi/10.1145/3404835.3462851

Olsson, E. J., Madison, G., & Ekström, A. G. (2025). Is Google liberal on immigration? Attitude bias, politicisation and filter bubbles in search engine result pages. Heliyon, 11(3), e42020. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2025.e42020